ANANI YAO KUWORNU

Department of Communication | 2130 Skinner Building, University of Maryland, College Park, MD 20742
akuwornu@umd.edu | yao.anani@gmail.com | ORCID: 0009-0002-5520-6658
UMD Profile | LinkedIn | Google Scholar

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Communication **Expected May 2027**

University of Maryland, College Park
Concentration: Strategic Communication and Public Relations; Crisis and Political Communication
Advanced to candidacy, June 2026
Dissertation: *Crisis Communication and Strategic Narratives in Public Diplomacy: Deconstructing the Narratives Around the U.S. Aid Withdrawal*
Committee: Dr. Nana Kwame Osei Fordjour (Chair), Dr. Brooke Fisher Liu, Dr. Sun Young Lee, Dr. Carly Woods, Dr. Sarah Elizabeth Croco (Dean's Representative)

M.A., Development Communication **October 2021**

University of Media, Arts and Communication (UniMAC), Accra, Ghana
Thesis: *Social Movements in the Digital Age: A Study of the #FixTheCountry Protest Campaign in Ghana*

M.Phil., Business Administration (Organizational & Human Resource Management) **July 2012**

University of Ghana Business School, Accra, Ghana
Thesis: *Human Capital Development Policy Framework for Ghana: Implications of Ghana's Constitution, the GPRS II Document, and the Agriculture and Energy Sectors*

B.A., Philosophy & Theatre Arts (Combined Major) **June 2005**

University of Ghana, Legon, Accra, Ghana

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Crisis and risk communication; strategic communication and public relations; artificial intelligence and emerging technology in public relations practice; political communication and public discourse; digital publics, incivility, and online political participation; computational and qualitative approaches to media text, with sustained attention to African and international contexts.

METHODS & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Computational text analysis (topic modeling, sentiment analysis, temporal and trend analysis); qualitative methods (semi-structured elite interviews, thematic analysis); rhetorical, framing, and content analysis.

Software: NVivo, R (including LexisNexis Tools), SentiStrength, Nexis Uni, Factiva, Google Analytics, Hootsuite, Microsoft 365.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Osei Fordjour, N. K., & **Kuwornu, A. Y.** (2026). Two decades of flooded stories: Unpacking media discourses on rain disasters and environmental risks in Ghana through machine learning. *Environmental Communication.* Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1080/17524032.2026.2665705

Osei Fordjour, N. K., Mohammed, I., & **Kuwornu, A. Y.** (2025). Uncivil discourses, online comments and politics: A case study of discussions surrounding Ghana's lithium deal. *Communicatio: South African Journal of Communication Theory and Research, 51*(1–2), 40–58. https://doi.org/10.1080/02500167.2025.2548779

Sikanku, E., Mensah, E. O., Kwansah-Aidoo, K., & **Kuwornu, Y. A.** (2023). Presidential rhetoric in a period of crisis: Analysing President Akufo-Addo's first major COVID-19 related television broadcast. *African Journal of Rhetoric, 15*(1), 300–321. *[Published as Y. A. Kuwornu]*

Book Chapters

Kuwornu, A. Y. (2026). Analysis of candidate speeches presented at the manifesto launch of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) and the New Patriotic Party (NPP) in Ghana. In G. E. Sikanku (Ed.), *Elections and communication in Ghana* (pp. 150–169). Woeli Publishing. ISBN 978-9988-42-755-9

Manuscripts Under Review

Kuwornu, A. Y. Themes and tones: A framing assessment of social media public response to Akufo-Addo's Volta disaster address. Submitted October 2026 to *Howard Journal of Communications*.

Manuscripts in Preparation

Kuwornu, A. Y., Otchere, F. A., & Edor, M. By the stroke of a pen: Assessing the global impact of defunding USAID. Target: *Journal of Contingencies and Crisis Management*.

Kuwornu, A. Y., & Otchere, F. A. Contextualizing public relations ethics: Practitioner perspectives on the IPR Ghana Code of Ethics. Target: *Journal of Public Relations Research*.

Kuwornu, A. Y. Who answers for the machine? Artificial intelligence, disclosure, and accountability in African government communication. Target: *Public Relations Inquiry*.

Kuwornu, A. Y. Artificial intelligence in external strategic communication, customer engagement, and reputation management: A multi-case study of Ghanaian banks. Target: *Journal of Communication Management*.

Anti, S. M., & **Kuwornu, A. Y.** AI affordances and public relations in Ghana's digital media landscape: A content analysis of media representations and organizational communication. Target: *Public Relations Review*.

Osei Fordjour, N. K., Dogbatse, F. S., **Kuwornu, A. Y.**, Aboagye, D. N., & Otchere, F. A. Strategic Impression Management: Understanding the Framing Choices of Candidates in the 2016 and 2020 U.S. Vice-Presidential Debates. Target: *International Journal of Communication*

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

IAMCR Annual Conference — Galway, Ireland **July 2026**

Kuwornu, A. Y., Okyere, F., & Anti, S. M. Digital diplomacy, soft power and narratives from the Global South: The case of IShowSpeed's Ghana tour. *[Paper accepted; not presented]*

IAMAS 2026 Conference — Concordia University, Montreal, Canada **June 2026**

Otchere, F. A., & **Kuwornu, A. Y.** Motherwork amid domestic violence among immigrant women in the US: Examining the centrality of housing stability to maternal health. *[Paper accepted; not presented]*

International Crisis and Risk Communication Conference (ICRCC) — Clemson University, SC **March 2026**

Kuwornu, A. Y., & Otchere, F. A. By the stroke of a pen: Assessing the global impact of defunding USAID. *High Impact Poster Session. Recipient, High Impact Poster Award (People's Choice).*

NCA 111th Annual Convention — Denver, CO **November 2025**

Kuwornu, A. Y., & Otchere, F. A. By the stroke of a pen: Assessing the global impact of defunding USAID.

NCA 110th Annual Convention — New Orleans, LA **November 2024**

Osei Fordjour, N. K., Mohammed, I., & **Kuwornu, A. Y.** Uncivil discourses, online comments, and politics: A case study of discussions surrounding Ghana's lithium deal. *(Presented on behalf of co-authors.)*

AEJMC Annual Conference — Philadelphia, PA **August 2024**

Kuwornu, A. Y. A comparative functional analysis of candidate speeches presented at the manifesto launch of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) and the New Patriotic Party (NPP) during the 2020 presidential elections in Ghana.

Kuwornu, A. Y. Themes and tones: A framing assessment of social media public response to Akufo-Addo's Volta disaster address.

AEJMC Midwinter Conference — Norman, OK **March 2024**

Kuwornu, A. Y. Themes and tones: A framing assessment of social media public response to Akufo-Addo's Volta disaster address.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Department of Communication, University of Maryland, College Park **August 2023 – Present**

Course	Role	Terms	Sections	Avg. enrolment
COMM 107 Oral Communication: Principles and Practices	Instructor of Record	Fall 2023 – Summer 2026	7	19
COMM 353 New Media Writing for Public Relations	Instructor of Record	Spring 2026; Fall 2026	2	9
COMM 449B Communication and Social Media	Instructor of Record	Fall 2026	1	30
COMM 201 Introduction to Public Relations	Teaching Assistant and Guest Lecturer	Fall 2024; Fall 2025	2	68

- Ten sections as instructor of record, with full responsibility for syllabus design, instruction, and assessment. Three sections delivered fully online: two three-week winter intensives and a six-week summer session.
- COMM 353 is built around a semester-long client project in which each major assignment becomes a component of a final proposal; students also complete Google Analytics and Hootsuite Social Marketing certifications.
- COMM 201: delivered lectures, facilitated discussion, held full responsibility for grading and assessment, and served as guest lecturer for the Issues and Crisis Communication session.
- Revised instructional methods each term on the basis of student feedback and an anonymous feedback instrument that remains open throughout the semester.

Selected Teaching Evaluations (0–4 scale)

- Inclusive classroom environment: 3.8 (Fall 2025) highest-rated dimension in every course taught. Approachability: 3.9.
- Teaching the same course a year apart, ratings rose from 3.3 to 3.7 for constructive feedback and from 3.2 to 3.8 for would-recommend.

Advising & Mentoring

- Advise undergraduates on scholarship and internship applications, including reference letters and interview preparation.
- Guide prospective graduate students on statements of purpose and writing samples.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Research Associate — Government & Public Affairs **June – August 2026**

Terra Davis Consulting, LLC, Washington, DC

- Conducted policy research and analysis supporting client engagement with federal elected officials and Federal Election Commission regulators.

Research Associate — Government & Public Affairs **June – August 2025**

National Association of Business Political Action Committees (NABPAC), Washington, DC

- Conducted policy research on corporate political engagement for member organizations; reported directly to the President & CEO.

Senior Communications Advisor **March 2019 – July 2023**

Tullow Ghana Limited (operator, Jubilee and TEN offshore fields), Accra, Ghana

- Directed reputation and issues management for the operator of Ghana's largest producing oil fields, managing an annual communications budget of approximately $60,000, two direct reports, and three external public relations agencies.
- Built and maintained a national media network of 55+ senior journalists and editors; certified six reporters in offshore safety training (BOSIET) to enable first-hand press access to offshore production facilities.
- Served as communications lead on the Incident Management Team across three major crisis events, coordinating operations, legal, and community relations under time pressure.
- Directed community engagement and local content communications across 30+ coastal communities; wrote talking points, briefing materials, and Q&A for the Managing Director and senior principals.

Development Outreach & Communications Specialist **September 2015 – February 2019**

U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID), West Africa Regional Mission

- Managed communications and reputation for the West Africa Mission with 15+ U.S. Embassy Public Affairs Sections and the Bureau for Legislative and Public Affairs, Washington, D.C.
- Supervised seven communications officers across implementing partners to execute a unified regional communications strategy.
- Led communications for flagship U.S. Government initiatives including Feed the Future and PEPFAR, and multilateral engagement with the ECOWAS Commission.

Public Diplomacy Officer (Alumni Coordinator) **April 2011 – September 2015**

Embassy of the United States of America, Accra, Ghana

- Founded and structured the Ghana–U.S. Alumni Association, converting a dispersed exchange-program network into a governed organization.
- Coordinated public diplomacy programming with Cultural Affairs staff and senior Embassy leadership, handling sensitive information under U.S. Government protocols.

Human Resources Officer **April 2008 – April 2011**

Bank of Africa (formerly Amalgamated Bank), Accra, Ghana

- Designed the bank's learning and development strategy and training policy; led end-to-end recruitment and advised executive management on workforce planning.

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

Faculty-Student Research Award (FSRA), College of Arts and Humanities, UMD 2025–26

With Dr. Nana Kwame Osei Fordjour (faculty lead). Project: media coverage of flooding in Ghana

Dean's Fellowship, University of Maryland, College Park 2023–2027

ARHU Summer Fellowship, University of Maryland, College Park 2024

HONORS & AWARDS

High Impact Poster Award (People's Choice), International Crisis and Risk Communication Conference, Clemson University 2026

For "By the Stroke of a Pen: Assessing the Global Impact of Defunding USAID"

Group Meritorious Award, USAID West Africa — multilateral support for the ECOWAS Commission, Abuja 2015

Group Meritorious Award — Robotics-Inspired Science Education across 40+ Ghanaian senior high schools 2012

SERVICE

Service to the Profession

Moderator, Top Refereed Student Research Paper Session, Political Communication Division, AEJMC Annual Conference, New Orleans, LA August 2026

Reviewer, National Communication Association (NCA) 2025
Reviewer, Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) 2024, 2025
Reviewer, Public Relations Division, International Communication Association (ICA) 2023
Student Volunteer, NCA 109th, 110th, and 111th Annual Conventions 2023 – 2025

Service to the Department & University

Treasurer / Fundraising Chair and Colloquium Representative, COMMGrads, UMD 2024

Service to the Community

National President, Graduate Students' Association of Ghana – USA (GRASAG-USA) 2025 – 2026

Lead a national organization serving Ghanaian graduate students across U.S. universities; oversee academic support, mentorship, and emergency financial assistance programming, and convene the association's annual Congress.

Non-Executive Director & Board Member, Life Link Friendship Schools, Ghana 2006 – Present
President, 1999 Accra Academy Old Students Association 2019 – 2025
Vice President, 1999 Accra Academy Old Students Association 2007 – 2019
General Secretary, Graduate Students Association, University of Ghana, Legon 2010 – 2011

PROFESSIONAL CERTIFICATIONS & TRAINING

International Minimum Industry Safety Training (Code 5750) 2022
Basic Offshore Safety Induction and Emergency Training with CA-EBS, OPITO-approved (Code 5312) 2019
Diplomatic Security Services, Diplomatic Security Training Center, West Virginia, USA 2017
Standard English Writing Proficiency, USAID, Accra, Ghana 2017
Development Outreach and Communication, USAID Bureau for Legislative and Public Affairs, Washington, D.C. 2016
Public Diplomacy Outreach and Strategy Building, Foreign Service Institute, Johannesburg 2013
New Media Diplomacy Strategy & Engagement, U.S. Embassy, Accra, Ghana 2012
Public Diplomacy Outreach and Strategy Building, Foreign Service Institute, Washington, D.C. 2011

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

Student Member, National Communication Association (NCA) 2023 – Present
Student Member, Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) 2023 – Present
Affiliate Member, Institute of Public Relations, Ghana 2024 – Present

REFERENCES

Dr. Nana Kwame Osei Fordjour
Assistant Professor, Department of Communication, University of Maryland
2110 Skinner Building, 4300 Chapel Lane, College Park, MD 20742-7635 | 301-405-6528 | nkoford@umd.edu

Dr. Brooke Fisher Liu
Professor and Distinguished Scholar-Teacher, Department of Communication, University of Maryland
Fellow of the International Communication Association
2110 Skinner Building, 4300 Chapel Lane, College Park, MD 20742-7635 | 301-405-6524 | bfliu@umd.edu

Dr. Sun Young Lee
Associate Professor and Co-Director of Graduate Studies, Department of Communication, University of Maryland
2110 Skinner Building, 4300 Chapel Lane, College Park, MD 20742-7635 | 301-405-8264 | sunlee@umd.edu